

Word family: **help / helps / helped / helping / helper / helpful / helpless / helplessness / unhelpful**

Base word: help

Third-person singular: helps

Past tense / past participle: helped

** -ing form:** helping

Related forms: helper, helpful, helpfully, helpless, helplessly, helplessness, unhelpful

Part of speech: verb (動詞) / noun (名詞) / related adjective and noun forms (相關形容詞及名詞)

Useful constructions/extensions: help someone, help someone do/to do something, help with something, help yourself, can't help doing, can't help but, be of help, with the help of, helpful advice, helpless, helping hand, a helping of food

Core meaning

The central idea of **help** is:

to make it easier for someone to do something, solve a problem, improve a situation, or avoid difficulty.

繁體中文 : ** 幫助 ; 協助 ; 令某人更容易完成某事或改善情況

1. **help someone (幫助某人) — 幫助 ; 協助**

The basic everyday meaning.

Meaning: To make something easier or better for another person.

Practice 1

> “She always **helps her family**.”

「她總是**幫助家人**。」

Practice 2

> “Can you **help me**?”

「你可以**幫我嗎**？」

help someone = 為某人提供協助 , 令對方更容易完成事情 / 解決困難

2. **help someone do something (幫某人做) — 幫助某人完成**

A major construction.

Practice 3

> “She **helped me carry** the bags.”

「她**幫我拿**那些袋。」

Practice 4

> “This book will **help you understand** the topic.”

「這本書會**幫助你理解**這個題目。」

help + person + base verb = 協助某人完成某項行動 / 達成某個結果

3. **help someone to do something (幫助某人做) — 幫助**

A standard variant.

Practice 5

> “She **helped me to prepare** for the interview.”

「她**幫助我準備**面試。」

Practice 6

> “Exercise can help you to sleep better.”

「運動可以**幫助你睡得更好**。」

help someone to do = help someone do ; 兩種結構都正確

In modern English, especially everyday use:

> **help someone do**

is often more concise and common.

4. **help with something (幫忙處理某事) — 幫忙 ; 協助**

A major construction.

Practice 7

> “Can you **help with the cooking**?”

「你可以**幫忙煮飯**嗎？」

Practice 8

> “She helped me with my homework.”

「她**幫我做 / 處理功課上的問題**。」

help with X = 協助處理某項工作、問題或活動

5. **help to improve/reduce/prevent (有助於) — 有助 ; 促進**

A major non-personal subject use.

Practice 9

> “Regular exercise **helps reduce stress**.”

「定期運動**有助減輕壓力**。」

Practice 10

> “Good communication can help prevent problems.”

「良好溝通**有助預防問題**。」

help = 令某個結果更容易發生 / 令情況改善

Here the subject does not need to be a person.

6. **help = contribute to a result (促成) — 有助於 ; 促進**

Practice 11

> “Her advice **helped** me make a better decision.”

「她的建議**幫助**我作出**更好**的決定。」

Practice 12

> “The new system helped improve efficiency.”

「新系統**有助**提高效率**。**」

help = 對某結果的出現提供正面作用，但不一定是唯一原因

7. **help** = assist in an emergency/problem (援助) — 援助；救助

A stronger context-specific sense.

Practice 13

> “Several people stopped to **help** after the accident.”

「意外後有幾個人停下來**幫忙 / 救助**。」

Practice 14

> “Call for help!”

「**求救！**」

help = 在危急、困難或需要支援時提供援助

8. **help** = noun: assistance (幫助) — 協助；援助

Now **help** is a noun.

Practice 15

> “Thank you for your **help**.”

「謝謝你的**幫助**。」

Practice 16

> “I need some help.”

「我需要一些**幫助**。」

help = 使某人更容易完成事情 / 解決問題的協助

Usually uncountable in this sense.

9. **ask for help (求助) — 請求幫助**

Practice 17

> “Don’t be afraid to **ask for help**.”

「不要害怕**求助**。」

Practice 18

> “She asked her colleague for help.”

「她向同事**尋求幫助**。」

ask for help = 主動請別人提供協助

10. **need help (需要幫助) — 需要協助**

Practice 19

> “I **need help** with this.”

「我這件事**需要幫忙**。」

Practice 20

> “He clearly needs professional help.”

「他顯然需要**專業協助**。」

need help = 自己無法完全處理，需要他人 / 專業支援

11. **be of help (有幫助) — 有用 ; 能幫上忙**

A common slightly formal expression.

Practice 21

> “I hope this information is **of help**.”

「希望這些資訊**對你有幫助**。」

Practice 22

> “Let me know if I can be of any help.”

「如果我**能幫上忙**，請告訴我。」

be of help = 對某人 / 某事有實際協助作用

12. **with the help of (在.....幫助下) — 在.....協助下**

A major fixed phrase.

Practice 23

> “I finished the project **with the help of** my team.”

「我**在團隊的幫助下**完成了項目。」

Practice 24

> “She recovered with the help of her family.”

「她**在家人的幫助下**逐漸恢復。」

with the help of X = 因得到 X 的協助而能完成 / 改善某事

13. **help yourself (請自便 / 自己拿) — 自己取用**

A major separate expression.

Practice 25

> “**Help yourself** to some fruit.”

「請**自己拿些水果吃 / 不用客氣**。」

Practice 26

> “Please help yourself to tea.”

「請**自己倒茶 / 隨便喝茶**。」

help yourself to X = 不用等別人招呼，自己自由拿取食物 / 飲品等

This is highly relevant to hospitality contexts like your passage.

14. **help yourself = take something freely (自行取用) — 自便**

Practice 27

> “There are snacks on the table—**help yourself**.”

「桌上有小食，**請自便**。」

Practice 28

> “Guests were told to help themselves.”

「客人被告知可以**自行取用**。」

help yourself = 自己拿 / 使用，不需要別人替你服務

15. **help yourself to someone's property (擅自取用) — 不問自取**

The same phrase can become negative depending on context.

Practice 29

> “He **helped himself to** my food without asking.”

「他沒有問我就**自行拿了我的食物**。」

Practice 30

> “Someone helped themselves to the money.”

「有人**擅自拿走了那筆錢**。」

help yourself to X = 自行拿取；若沒有獲准，可帶「擅自取用」意味

Context matters.

16. **can't help doing (忍不住做) — 忍不住；不由自主**

A major idiomatic sense.

Practice 31

> “I **can't help smiling** when I see her.”

「我看見她時**忍不住微笑**。」

Practice 32

> “She couldn't help laughing.”

「她**忍不住笑了**。」

can't help doing = 無法阻止自己產生某種反應 / 做某事

Here **help** does not mean “assist.”

17. **can't help but + verb (不禁；不能不) — 忍不住；不由得**

Practice 33

> “I **can't help but admire** her.”

「我**不禁敬佩**她。」

Practice 34

> “You can't help but notice the difference.”

「你**不可能不注意到 / 不禁注意到**這個差別。」

can't help but do = 某種反應幾乎無法避免

18. **help it (避免 / 控制某事) — 控制 ; 阻止**

A less obvious but very useful expression.

Practice 35

> “I’m sorry—I **couldn’t help it**.”

「對不起，我**控制不了 / 也沒辦法**。」

Practice 36

> “If I can help it, I won’t work late.”

「**如果可以避免的話**，我不會加班到很晚。」

help it = 阻止 / 避免某種情況發生

This appears especially in:

> **can’t help it**

> **if I can help it**

19. **if I can help it (如果可以避免) — 如果有得選 / 如果能避免**

Practice 37

> “I won’t miss another visit **if I can help it**.”

「**如果可以避免的話**，我不會再錯過探訪。」

Practice 38

> “I never drive in heavy traffic if I can help it.”

「如果**可以避免**，我從不在塞車時段開車。」

****if I can help it = 如果事情在我的控制範圍內，我會設法避免****

20. ****there's no helping it (無可避免) — 沒辦法；無可奈何****

A fixed expression.

Practice 39

> “We’ll have to cancel. ****There’s no helping it.****”

「我們只能取消，****沒有辦法了****。」

Practice 40

> “The damage is done; there’s no helping it now.”

「事情已造成損害，現在****也無可奈何****。」

****there's no helping it = 情況已無法改變 / 避免****

21. ****help = noun: person who assists (幫手；助手) — 幫手****

A countable use, though often context-dependent.

Practice 41

> “We hired some extra ****help**** for the event.”

「我們為活動請了一些額外****幫手 / 人手****。」

Practice 42

> “She could use an extra pair of hands and some help.”

「她需要多一些****人手幫忙****。」

****help = 提供協助的人 / 人手****

This use is especially common collectively.

22. **the help** (傭工 / 受僱幫工 ; 需注意語氣) — 家傭 / 幫工

A socially marked use.

Practice 43

> “The phrase **the help** can refer to domestic workers.”

「**the help** 可以指家務傭工。」

Practice 44

> “In many contexts, more specific terms such as domestic worker are preferable.”

「在很多語境中，使用更具體的 **domestic worker** 等詞會更合適。」

the help = 傳統上指家庭受僱幫工 / 傭人 ; 現代使用時需注意語氣與社會語感

Recognition is useful; active use should be cautious.

23. **helper** (幫手 ; 助手) — 幫忙的人

A direct person noun.

Practice 45

> “She was a great **helper** in the kitchen.”

「她在廚房裡是個很好的**幫手**。」

Practice 46

> “We need two helpers for the event.”

「活動需要兩名**助手 / 幫手**。」

helper = 幫助別人完成工作的某個人

24. **helpful** (有幫助的) — 有用 ; 有幫助

A major adjective.

Practice 47

> “Her advice was very **helpful**.”

「她的建議非常**有幫助**。」

Practice 48

> “The guide gave us some helpful information.”

「指南提供了一些**有用的資訊**。」

helpful = 能令某件事更容易、令人更容易理解 / 解決問題的

25. **helpful person** (樂於助人的) — 樂於幫助；肯幫忙

A second common adjective use.

Practice 49

> “The staff were very **helpful**.”

「職員非常**樂於幫忙 / 很願意協助**。」

Practice 50

> “She is always helpful when someone has a problem.”

「有人遇到問題時，她總是很**樂於助人**。」

helpful = 願意提供實際協助的

The same adjective can describe either:

- * useful information/things;
- * cooperative/helping people.

26. **helpfully** (有幫助地 / 好心地) — 有用地；主動協助地

Practice 51

> “She **helpfully** explained what I needed to do.”

「她很**好心** / 有幫助地解釋了**我要做甚麼**。」

Practice 52

> “The instructions helpfully include examples.”

「說明書很**貼心地** / 有用地**附上了例子**。」

helpfully = 以對別人有實際幫助的方式

27. **helpless** (無能為力的) — 無法自助；無能為力

A major related adjective with an important meaning shift.

Practice 53

> “I felt **helpless**.”

「我感到**無能為力**。」

Practice 54

> “The child was completely helpless without an adult.”

「沒有成年人幫助，那個孩子完全**無法自理 / 無助**。」

helpless = 無法自己改善情況、保護自己或採取有效行動

28. **helpless** = unable to control a reaction (控制不了) — 無法控制

Practice 55

> “She burst into **helpless laughter**.”

「她笑得**完全控制不了自己**。」

Practice 56

> “He watched in helpless frustration.”

「他只能**無能為力又沮喪地**看著。」

****helpless = 無法控制局面 / 反應，沒有有效辦法改變事情****

29. ****helplessness (無助感) — 無能為力；無助****

Practice 57

> “She felt a sense of ****helplessness****.”

「她感到一種****無助感****。」

Practice 58

> “His helplessness made the situation more painful.”

「他的****無能為力****令情況更加難受。」

****helplessness = 無法控制、改善或應付某情況的狀態 / 感受****

30. ****unhelpful (沒有幫助的) — 無用；幫倒忙****

A useful opposite.

Practice 59

> “That comment was ****unhelpful****.”

「那個評論****沒有幫助 / 反而添亂****。」

Practice 60

> “The instructions were vague and unhelpful.”

「那些指示含糊，而且****沒有實際幫助****。」

****unhelpful = 沒有令問題更容易理解 / 解決，甚至可能令情況更差****

31. ****a helping hand (幫一把) — 幫忙；援手****

A major idiom.

Practice 61

> “Everyone needs a **helping hand** sometimes.”

「每個人有時都需要別人**幫一把**。」

Practice 62

> “She gave me a helping hand with the boxes.”

「她**幫我一把**，一起搬箱子。」

a helping hand = 實際提供的協助 / 援手

32. **lend/give a helping hand** (伸出援手) — 幫忙

Practice 63

> “Neighbours came to **lend a helping hand**.”

「鄰居都來**伸出援手**。」

Practice 64

> “Can you give me a helping hand?”

「你可以**幫我一把嗎**？」

lend/give a helping hand = 主動提供實際協助

33. **helping** = serving of food (一份食物) — 一份 ; 一客

A completely separate noun sense.

Practice 65

> “He had a second **helping** of dessert.”

「他又吃了第二**份甜品**。」

Practice 66

> “Would you like another helping of rice?”

「你想再來一**份飯**嗎？」

a helping = 一次盛給某人吃的食物份量

This is genuinely different from “assistance.”

34. **second helping (第二份食物) — 再添一份**

Practice 67

> “She asked for a **second helping**.”

「她要求**再添一份**。」

Practice 68

> “The food was so good that everyone wanted a second helping.”

「食物太好吃了，大家都想**再添一份**。」

second helping = 同一道食物再吃一份

35. **self-help (自助) — 自助；自我改善**

A major compound.

Practice 69

> “She reads **self-help books**.”

「她看**自助 / 自我成長書籍**。」

Practice 70

> “The course focuses on self-help strategies.”

「課程著重於**自助策略**。」

****self-help = 依靠自己採取方法改善心理、生活、技能或問題****

36. ****self-help book (自我成長書) — 自助書****

Practice 71

> “The book is marketed as a ****self-help book****.”

「這本書被定位為一本****自我成長 / 自助書****。」

Practice 72

> “Self-help books often offer practical advice.”

「****自助書****通常提供實用建議。」

****self-help book = 旨在幫助讀者自行改善生活、習慣、心理或能力的書****

Important distinction: ****help vs assist****

These overlap strongly.

****help****

= everyday, broad.

****assist****

= more formal and often task-specific.

> “Can you help me?”

very natural.

> “Can you assist me?”

more formal/service-oriented.

Important distinction: ****help vs support****

help

= directly make a task/situation easier.

support

= provide ongoing practical, emotional, financial, or organizational backing.

Your grandmother may:

> help you with something

and also:

> support you emotionally.

Not identical.

Important distinction: **help vs aid**

help

= broad everyday word.

aid

= more formal and especially common in:

* humanitarian aid;

* medical aid;

* financial aid.

> “foreign aid”

is more idiomatic than:

> “foreign help.”

Important distinction: **help vs save**

help

= make a problem easier/better.

save

= rescue from serious danger/loss, or prevent destruction/failure.

Helping someone does not necessarily mean saving them.

Important distinction: **help vs solve**

help

= assist toward a result.

solve

= fully find the answer/remove the problem.

> "She helped me solve the problem."

means:

> she contributed, but the solving is the final result.

Important distinction: **help someone do vs do something for someone**

help someone cook

= both may participate.

cook for someone

= you perform the cooking for them.

So **help** does not automatically mean doing the whole task.

Important distinction: **help with vs help to**

help with + noun

> “Help with the report.”

help + person + (to) verb

> “Help me write the report.”

Different grammar, similar assistance concept.

Important distinction: **help + verb vs help to + verb**

Both are standard:

> “This helps reduce stress.”

> “This helps to reduce stress.”

The version without **to** is especially common in modern English.

Important distinction: **helpful = useful vs helpful = willing to help**

Compare:

> “That information is helpful.”

= useful.

> “The receptionist was helpful.”

= cooperative and willing to assist.

Same adjective, different target.

Important distinction: **helpful vs useful**

useful

= has a practical use/value.

helpful

= specifically assists someone in understanding, solving, or doing something.

A knife is:

> useful

but usually not:

> helpful

unless discussing how it helps accomplish a task.

Important distinction: **helpful vs thoughtful**

These can overlap in interpersonal situations.

helpful

= provides practical assistance.

thoughtful

= shows careful consideration of another person's needs/feelings.

Your grandmother's advice may be both:

> helpful

and:

> thoughtful.

But the qualities differ.

Important distinction: **helpless vs hopeless**

These are often confused.

helpless

= unable to act effectively / unable to help yourself.

hopeless

= without hope, or extremely bad at something in informal use.

> “I felt helpless.”

= 我無能為力。

> “The situation felt hopeless.”

= 情況看似沒有希望。

Different focus.

Important distinction: **helpless vs powerless**

helpless

= unable to protect/help yourself or change a situation.

powerless

= lacking power/control to influence it.

They overlap, but **helpless** often carries stronger vulnerability.

Important distinction: **unhelpful vs useless**

unhelpful

= does not assist the situation.

useless

= has no practical value/use.

Useless is often stronger.

> “His comment was unhelpful.”

= it did not improve things.

> “The broken tool is useless.”

= it cannot serve its function.

Important distinction: ****help yourself literal vs idiomatic****

Literal-looking phrase:

> “Help yourself to some tea.”

does not mean:

> assist yourself with a problem.

It means:

> freely take some tea yourself.

This must be learned as an expression.

Important distinction: ****help yourself vs serve yourself****

These are close.

****help yourself****

= invitation to freely take food/drink.

****serve yourself****

= physically put the food onto your own plate/cup.

At a buffet, you may do both.

Important distinction: ****help yourself vs take without permission****

Context changes the tone.

Invited:

> “Help yourself to fruit.”

= 請自便。

Not invited:

> “He helped himself to my money.”

= 他擅自拿了我的錢。

Same construction; permission makes the difference.

Important distinction: **can't help doing vs don't want to**

can't help doing

= reaction feels uncontrollable.

don't want to do

= preference/intention.

> “I can't help laughing.”

does not mean:

> “I want to laugh.”

It means:

> laughter happens despite attempts to control it.

Important distinction: **can't help doing vs can't do**

I can't swim

= lack ability.

I can't help smiling

= cannot prevent the reaction.

Different role of **help**.

Important distinction: can't help it vs it can't be helped

I can't help it

= I cannot control/prevent my behaviour or the situation.

It can't be helped

= the situation cannot be avoided/fixed.

> "I laugh when I'm nervous—I can't help it."

versus:

> "The flight is cancelled. It can't be helped."

37. it can't be helped (沒辦法) — 無可奈何

A major expression.

Practice 73

> "The weather ruined the event, but **it can't be helped**."

「天氣破壞了活動，但也**沒辦法**。」

Practice 74

> "We have to wait. It can't be helped."

「我們只能等，**也無可奈何**。」

it can't be helped = 情況無法避免 / 改變，只能接受

Important distinction: helping = assistance vs helping = food portion

Compare:

> “Helping others is important.”

Here:

****helping**** = the act of assisting.

But:

> “a second helping of cake”

Here:

****helping**** = a serving/portion.

Genuinely separate meanings.

Important distinction: **helper vs assistant**

**helper**

= general person who helps, often informal.

**assistant**

= may be an official job/role.

A volunteer can be:

> a helper

without holding an:

> assistant position.

Important distinction: **self-help vs professional help**

**self-help**

= methods someone uses independently.

**professional help**

= assistance from trained professionals.

They are not mutually exclusive.

Family-extension sweep

The practical **help** family is rich in assistance, usefulness, inability to control, self-service, and several lexicalized extensions:

- * **help someone** = 幫助某人
- * **help someone do/to do** = 幫助某人做
- * **help with something** = 幫忙處理某事
- * **help improve/reduce/prevent** = 有助於改善 / 減少 / 預防
- * **help — noun** = 幫助 / 援助
- * **ask for help** = 求助
- * **need help** = 需要幫助
- * **be of help** = 有幫助 / 幫得上忙
- * **with the help of** = 在.....幫助下
- * **help yourself** = 請自便 / 自行取用
- * **help yourself to X** = 自己拿取 X ; 未經允許時可指擅自取用
- * **can't help doing** = 忍不住做
- * **can't help but do** = 不禁 / 不能不
- * **can't help it** = 控制不了 / 沒辦法
- * **if I can help it** = 如果可以避免
- * **it can't be helped** = 沒辦法 / 無可奈何
- * **helper** = 幫手 / 助手
- * **helpful — useful** = 有幫助的 / 有用的
- * **helpful — person** = 樂於助人的
- * **helpfully** = 有幫助地 / 好心地
- * **helpless** = 無助 / 無能為力的
- * **helplessness** = 無助感 / 無能為力
- * **unhelpful** = 沒有幫助的
- * **helping hand** = 援手 / 幫一把
- * **a helping of food** = 一份食物
- * **second helping** = 再添一份
- * **self-help** = 自助 / 自我改善
- * **self-help book** = 自我成長 / 自助書

The main semantic branches are:

> **provide assistance**

> **make a result easier or more likely**

> **assistance as a noun**

> **self-service**

> **inability to control/avoid something in fixed expressions**

> **food portion**

plus the adjective family:

> **helpful / helpless / unhelpful**

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
-----	-----
help someone	為某人提供協助，使事情更容易完成 / 改善
help someone do/to do	協助某人完成某項行動或達成結果
help with X	協助處理某項工作、問題或活動
help + result	對某結果的出現提供正面作用 / 促進作用
help — noun	使某人更容易完成事情 / 解決問題的協助
ask for help	主動請求別人提供協助
be of help	對某人 / 某事有實際協助作用
with the help of	因得到某人 / 某物協助而完成或改善某事
help yourself	在獲准情況下自行拿取食物 / 飲品；請自便
help yourself to X	自行拿取 X；若沒有許可，可表示擅自取用
can't help doing	無法阻止自己產生某種反應 / 行動；忍不住
can't help but do	某種反應幾乎不可避免；不禁
can't help it	無法控制 / 避免自己的反應或情況
if I can help it	如果事情在控制範圍內，會設法避免
it can't be helped	情況無法避免 / 改變，只能接受
helper	為別人提供實際協助的人
helpful — thing	能令事情更容易理解、完成或解決的
helpful — person	願意並能提供實際協助的
helpless	無法自己改善情況、保護自己或採取有效行動
helplessness	無法控制 / 改善情況的無助狀態
unhelpful	沒有令事情更容易理解 / 解決，甚至可能添麻煩
helping hand	實際提供的援助 / 幫忙
a helping	一次盛給某人食用的食物份量
self-help	依靠自己採取方法改善生活、能力或問題

For your passage context

Although **help** itself is not one of the key lexical items in the grandmother passage, it fits the passage's meaning network very naturally.

Your grandmother:

- > makes tea
- > cuts fruit
- > listens
- > gives advice
- > provides stability and comfort

These are all ways in which someone can:

- > **help others**

But **help** should not be reduced to:

- > doing a task for someone.

It can also mean:

- > making a situation easier
- > supporting improvement
- > giving practical assistance
- > contributing to a positive result.

The most important learner contrasts are:

- > **help me**

> = 幫我

- > **help me carry this**

> = 幫我拿這個

- > **help with the cooking**

> = 幫忙煮飯

- > **exercise helps reduce stress**

> = 運動有助減壓

- > **ask for help**

> = 求助

- > **with her help**

> = 在她幫助下

> ****help yourself to some tea****

> = 請自己倒茶 / 隨便喝

> ****I can't help laughing****

> = 我忍不住笑

> ****I can't help it****

> = 我控制不了 / 沒辦法

> ****if I can help it****

> = 如果可以避免的話

> ****it can't be helped****

> = 沒辦法 / 無可奈何

> ****helpful advice****

> = 有幫助的建議

> ****a helpful person****

> = 樂於助人的人

> ****feel helpless****

> = 感到無能為力

> ****an unhelpful comment****

> = 沒有幫助的評論

> ****lend a helping hand****

> = 幫一把 / 伸出援手

> ****a second helping of food****

> = 再添一份食物

So ****help**** is much richer than simply:

> ****help = 幫助****

The biggest learner traps are:

> ****help yourself****

> = 自己拿 / 請自便

> ****can't help doing****

> = 忍不住做

> **it can't be helped**

> = 沒辦法

> **a helping of food**

> = 一份食物

These meanings are especially important because they cannot be translated correctly by mechanically using **「幫助」** every time.